Geography of Hykaen:

A Brief History of Nations:

On Hykaen, there are two main continents, nearest each other at the North and South poles, and separated otherwise by vast, violent oceans. The larger of these is known as the Lost Continent of Grok, and was once home to the majority of mortal races, their nations sprawling across its broad expanse. Eventually, though, these races sought to explore the unknown, and so they built ships to carry them across the oceans, and, after a great deal of difficulty, succeeded in reaching the new continent. Almost every nation sent colonists to this new land, and these founded new kingdoms, pushing out or subjugating the native goblinoid tribes. Due to the cyclical nature of the two great Stormseas, these colonial kingdoms quickly became independent from their mother kingdoms, but the benefits of trade still kept them connected, with the New Kingdoms shipping ore, grain, wood, and exotic oils, spices, and fruit back to their mother nations, and the mother nations reciprocating with finished products, new technology, and culture.

For the Eladrin and Elves of Jerisear, though, the drive and methods of colonization were different. Long occupied with divination and precognition, the wizards of the Twin Towers of Onyx and Ivory in the city of Arimensan connected several prophetic texts with new findings that emphatically said that the survival of the two peoples would be inextricably tied to the strength of their presence on the New Continent. Due to the presence of the land bridge over the North Pole, and the Elven affinity for cold weather, the nation had already established a number of outposts in the new land, most military, to keep watch over the Frost Giants of Hroww and to keep them from crossing the land bridge and conquering Jerisear. To that end, a pair of mighty fortresses, known today as Ripliesser and Ripliankch, were built on each side of the land bridge, intended to halt the advance of the Giants and their elemental allies in the event of an attack.

With the new information garnered by the stuffy academics of the Towers, however, the Sear peoples began a

campaign of expansion, carefully pushing out from their iron redoubts to raze Frost Giant holds and establish their own. The Giants, who were far less dangerous than the Sear's caution had lead them to believe, put up some token resistance before retreating to their clanholds in the Hroww mountains, ceding the northern taiga forests to the Sear. These established a citadel around a fey spring discovered in the east part of these, and that grew over time into a thriving city known as Searan, with many academies of magic, arts, and sciences. The expansion of the Sear across the north also continued, several more cities founded, including Qesteran and Illeran, and the Jerisear offshoot became known as Mansear.

Because of their control of the land bridge, Mansear was the only New Kingdom that didn't lose contact with their mother nation during a Storm Year. Thus, they were the only ones who knew of the problems that plagued the Lost Continent at the beginning of the Demonstorms. This period of intractable oceans lasted for a decade, and while merchants and leaders of the South kingdoms worried somewhat about the interminable nature of the storms, they were preoccupied with their own worries, their power struggles, and the sudden appearance of the conquering Duchy of Ulfendon, a small principality that had rapidly grown in size and influence under the ambitious leadership of its Duke. The Sear, however, heard the details of the darkness from their Jerisear kin—of the sudden and inexplicable explosion of Gnoll and Orc populations, of the sightings of greater Demons in the countryside and in battle, and of the overnight disappearances of Dwarf clanholds, Human towns, and even cosmopolitan cities. They sent messengers to the South kingdoms informing them of the troubles plaguing their mothers, but the South ignored them. When all the kingdoms on the Lost Continent had collapsed save Jerisear, Mansear called again for aid, and began to restore and garrison their fortress of Ripliankch. When all the enclaves of Jerisear had been destroyed, the Towers of their academies razed, they called again for aid, and received none. While the defenders at Ripliesser held their ground and gave their last for the last refugees fleeing the Abyssal horde to escape, still no help came. Only when the last messenger from Jerisear reached Riplianckh with the dreaded news

of Ripliesser's fall did help arrive, in the form of a host lead by the Duke of Ulfendon, whose conquest and rapid expansion was a last-ditch effort to rally enough forces from the Southern Kingdoms to reinforce the Sear and repulse the Demon horde. Their presence, as well as some powerful magic from Gram Marx, the Duke's Wizard, allowed the Sear to halt the horde and destroy the land bridge, removing their access to the New Continent.

In gratitude, each of the Searan Houses that had survived their ordeal pledged an elite warrior, scout, arcanist, artist, or scholar to the Duke's banner. These fourteen individuals and their families served in the Duke's court, and represented both the support of the Sear and their bond with the Southern kingdom. The Duke then went south again with his armies, and with the knowledge of his great deeds passing ahead of him, he successfully completed his conquest of the South, uniting all the disparate kingdoms south of the Paghfirld steppes under a single banner. Bards and historians from this time onward began use the expression "From Sear to Ulf" to signify a great distance, and the term began to refer to the continent itself; "Sear to Ulf'' eventually became "Sear-Ulf", and that is what the continent is called to this day.

This gift of talent was the first in a long line of exchanges, wherein Ulfin and other Southern students and experts would travel to Mansear to study with their experts, and Searan students would travel south to learn of the richly varied traditions and techniques of the lands under Ulfendon's banner. Said lands experienced unprecedented prosperity, with open borders for goods, trade, and travel, and a nearly complete lack of armed conflict under the First Duke's sons and daughters. Magic and engineering advanced to the point that the Ulfin academy built a second city atop the capital, Ulf, raised many meters into the sky. Landmark advances were made in negotiating with the Paghfirld tribes for their rights and trade. Several expeditions to explore the Lost Continent were also made, though very few returned, and everyone that did brought tales of horror and desolation. Many storm-blasted islands, notably the Isles of Want, near Ulf, were settled to mine ores and explore ancient archaeological sites.

Suddenly, though, 200 years after the conclusion of his conquest, the First Duke's line died out, with a sickly but wise 9th Duke dying with no children, and his cousin, who was next in line, vanishing strangely. This left a power vacuum, in spite of the contingencies put into place by the Second Duke, and wars broke out, with each nation in Ulfendon either vying for a successor or for their own sovereignty. Some succeeded in that last, like the fiercely independent Antara, at the extreme north of Ulfendon, who wanted nothing more to do with an imperial government. Some succeeded in the former, like the various Sulessé princes who banded together in favor of appointing a Steward of the Throne, who would watch over Ulfendon until the lost heir could be found. Said Steward, though, had greatly limited powers compared to the old Dukes, and the bureaucratic expansion that occurred as the Steward and the Duke's other lieutenants desperately tried to put what they perceived as the First Duke's vision into law and procedure lead to Ulfendon's sphere of influence continually shrinking and shrinking until the Steward, ostensibly ruler of the entire South, instead controlled merely the capital of Ulf and its nearest villages.

That is how it is today, another 200 years later, with an inflated bureaucracy intended to run a sprawling empire instead running a single, albeit incredibly large, city, and old rivalries and conflicts between different nations reignited. Searan exchanges still occur, but far less frequently, and the uncertainty and lack of security has lead to fear and xenophobia running rampant, with minority races like Deva, Tieflings, Dragonborn, Shifters, and Warforged, as well as those Paghfirld living in the Southern nations, receiving the brunt of it. This uncertainty has also lead to an explosion of different cults, ranging from secretive worshipers of obscure avatars or primal spirits to violent and bloodthirsty daemoniacs and devil-worshipers.

This is the world in which your character was raised. Think about their upbringing—did they have parents who feared others and pushed them away? Did they grow up in the lap of luxury in a successful merchant's home or noble house? Did they display talent or a drive to learn and attend an academy, whether in

Mansear or the South? Did they, perhaps, grow up on the streets or in the wilds, surviving on their wits? What do they think of the gods and their servants? What about arcanists, or soldiers? How well do they know their history? These are the sorts of questions to ask as you try to fit your character into the tumultuous world of Sear-Ulf.

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Regions Of Sear-Ulf:

As Sear-Ulf is a vast continent, it includes a vast array of climates, features, and ecosystems. Perhaps the greatest unifying element of these are the mountains. Beginning in the extreme north, and including the broad valley where stands Riplianckh, the mountains advance almost unbroken to the west and then south, composing the massive, deadly peaks of Hroww, and merging into the Paghfirld steppes near the middle of the continent. The mountains again resume at the eastern side of the Paghfirld, traveling south again past the planet's equator as the softer Torulf range and rounding out at the extreme south edge, tapering off into tall-cliffed, fjord-ridden islands off the west side of Turru.

These mountains rather neatly divide the continent into three parts: The North, where the mountains are north and west, the South, where they are East and South, and the Paghfirld, where they are not mountains but steppes and deserts.

The North consists of three main regions: the Hroww mountains and plateau in the west, the Erester River basin in the southeast, and the Lengfell tundra plains in the northeast. The Hroww is dominated by its Frost Giant overlords, whose clan infighting and brutal slavery makes it inhospitable for all but the toughest and most powerful of other races. The Sear maintain several forts in the foothills to protect the sources of the Erester, but any more presence is too risky and too expensive to maintain—Hroww blizzards and altitude are hard on even the most cold-aligned Sear. The Erester River flows east from the Hroww foothills, gaining in volume from its tributaries as it flows to the sea. The basin itself is very wet—it falls at a latitude such that water-drenched ocean storms travel west across it for most of the

year, dumping water and snow, depending on the season, and such storms stop at the Hroww, dumping the rest of their contents on the slopes. As a result, the basin is heavily wooded, with forests ranging from cold deciduous on the south side of the basin, to thick, temperate rainforests near the rivers and lakes, to dryer, colder, taiga on the north side, bordering the Lengfell. The basin covers the largest area of the three regions, and contains far more settlements and people than the others. The capital of Mansear, Searan, is built on the hills surrounding a fey spring, just northeast of the Erester's last bend before the ocean, and the basin has two other major cities: Qesteran and Illeran. Scattered throughout the basin are smaller villages and enclaves where most of the Elf population lives, while the Eladrin tend to congregate in the cities and at military installations. The Lengfell is not especially hospitable, and only a few of the hardiest bands of Elves and the most obstinate native Goblinoids live there, with the exceptions of a few military and research outposts including Riplianckh.

There are five major geographic regions in the South, bound by the Torulf mountains in the east and the oceans in the west. In the southeast, in temperate regions, you find broad moors and highlands surrounding the Grammere, an inland, (mostly) freshwater sea, and enclosed on the east by the peaks of the Torulfs. This is the location of the original Duchy of Ulfendon, which was nestled in a not-particularly fertile part directly adjacent to the mountains, but containing a unique feature: a canyon through the mountains that lead to an unusually sheltered cove and harbor that would protect its contents from the ravages of a Storm Year. This is where the three-tiered city of Ulf was built, and it's unique status as an oceanic access to the otherwise landlocked highlands, as well as its status, for many years, as the Capital of the South, made it an economic and cultural powerhouse and transformed the Ulfin Highlands into a far more developed and cosmopolitan region than it had been previously.

Traveling north from the highlands, away from the Grammere, a traveler finds the high deserts of Inmou. Here the Torulfs and the land are higher, and the rainshadow caused by the peaks means little rain falls. The peoples here are hardy, and a few cities

do exist, built around the few rivers that flow down from the mountains and dry out before joining the more plentiful water to the west. Ores and minerals are common, both in the mountains and in select parts of the desert, and the natives deal in both these and luxury goods, weaving carpets and creating oils, delicacies, and drinks from the unique desert flora and fauna. Nomadic tribes are fairly common, especially in the hotter, dryer, north, and they tend to stumble across old ruins from time immemorial.

Go west from the Ulfin Highlands, and you reach the Marengian Lowlands, a broad and fertile expanse of rolling, grassy plains and mixed forests. This is the breadbasket of the south, exporting grains and fruits to all the surrounding nations. The population is large, but spread across the entire plain, with no cities and only temporary towns whenever lords gather for a tournament. There are a number of different kingdoms on the plains, and during the summer, when crops are not being planted or harvested, the various knights and lords will often gather, either for tournaments or to wage war against each other. These wars are, as a rule, not serious. Soldiers will refrain from killing valuable opponents who could instead be ransomed, and ruining another lord's peasants or crops is frowned upon. These wars are always concluded by the end of the summer, usually with a treaty and an exchange of land. When faced by an outside threat, however, all the constant, playful, infighting turns to an advantage as the various lords meet, appoint a Marshal, and ride out in a disciplined storm. Many are the Sulesse or Korabathi warlords who saw the constant infighting of the Marengi to be a weakness, only to invade and find numerous strong-walled castles, thundering cavalry with wicked lances, and a unified opposition, regardless of the time of year.

South of the Marengian Lowlands are the seafarers of Korabath. Korabath is a small, harsh, land, heavily wooded and very rocky, that stretches south from the edge of the plains to the near-barren strips of land just south of the much smaller West Torulfs. The Korabathi used to be raiders and conquerors, but now their activities are mostly limited to mercenary work and trade. Many experts consider Korabathi Elves, Dwarves, and Humans to be an offshoot of their Ulfin brethren, and while

their quick alliance with and wholehearted support of the conquering Duke supports this, their culture and language are distinct enough to merit their own categorization.

North of the Lowlands are the wide and varied lands of the Sulesse, stretching north far past the equator and touching the south edge of the Paghfirld. Through the Sulesse flows the river Liv, which has its origins in the Grammere in the Ulfin highlands, as well as several other major riverine systems, some of which merge with the Liv. Ulf is the largest city in Sear-Ulf, but the largest Sulesse cities give it a run for its money, and they act as nexuses of commerce and culture in the west. These cities prefer their independence from one another, and will often have their own laws and lawmaking customs, unique to the country around them. They all, however, follow a set of bylaws that govern trade and travel throughout the region. The region's climate ranges from subtropical to tropical, and it's environments are mostly wide savannahs, dense jungles, fetid swamps, and crowded cities. The wide, shallow, Liv river is only really navigable by barge, but these and other flat-bottomed ships carry goods from the Grammere to the sea, where faster oceanic vessels can take them to ports along the Marengian coast. There are a number of Sulesse city-states, as well as a few nations.

The Paghfirld Wildlands lie in between Mansear and the Southlands. They are vast steppes, sprawling forests, and deserts, poorly-mapped and full of mysteries. The primary inhabitants are goblin tribes who escaped subjugation at the hands of the colonizing Southlanders.